

Issue 84 | The Attention Economy is Dead. Welcome to the Attention Society.

The three phases of how attention evolved from an economic commodity into a civilizational condition, and why this matters now.

MAR 20, 2026

IoNTELLIGENCE helps high performers make sense of a rapidly changing world defined by AI and attention overload.

Read IoNTELLIGENCE to **Upgrade Your Brain, Master AI, and Become an Attention Capitalist.**

Derek Thompson recently argued that “Everything is Television.” I agree. But I would push the idea one level deeper:

Everything is TV now. But attention is everything.

The phrase “Attention Economy” has become trite and too narrow to describe the world we actually inhabit. Attention hasn’t become less important, however. It’s evolved into something categorically different. Attention has escaped the market and now runs the world.

**Thank you for reading IoNTELLIGENCE. If
you want to support my writing and**

**podcasting, please consider becoming a
paid Member of our Community.**

✓ **Subscribed**

**ATTENTION
IS ALL
YOU NEED**

How We Got Here

The concept of an Attention Economy did useful work for about two decades, but it now explains only a small slice of life. It was born in economics, so it frames attention as a commodity. That lens works well for advertising, media, and platforms. However, it broke down the moment attention began to shape identity, politics, culture, and cognition.

The Big Idea

The 30-year economic evolution from monetizing time to organizing society.

	Phase 1: Attention Economy (1995-2012)	Phase 2: Dopamine Capitalism (2012-2023)	Phase 3: Attention Society (2023-Present)
CORE MECHANISM	Attention is measured, packaged, and sold. Mining your time.	Engineering behavior. Manipulating your nervous system.	Attention serves as the primary organizing principle.
BUSINESS MODEL	Advertising and attention capture.	Habit loops and behavior design.	Attention as strategic capital and competitive advantage.
SOCIETAL SCALE	A Market Dynamic.	A Behavioral System.	A Civilizational Condition.

© NotebookLM

Here's a simplified headline of the economic history of the last three decades:

We've moved from monetizing attention, to engineering behavior, to organizing society around attention itself.

Three phases explain how we arrived at this point. Each one represents not just a new business model, but a new relationship between human attention and the systems competing to capture it.

1. Attention Economy (1995–2012)

Attention is measured, packaged, and sold. Platforms monetize it through advertising. Behavioral influence occurred, but it remained relatively crude.

Google's PageRank was the era's defining mechanism: organize the world's information, sell the margin between what people sought and what advertisers wanted them to find. The product was eyeballs, and the currency was time. The manipulation, by later standards, was blunt.

2. Dopamine Capitalism (2012–2023)

Whereas the Attention Economy mined your *time*, Dopamine Capitalism manipulated your *nervous system*.

In this model, products use variable rewards and social validation to trigger habit loops that drive compulsive behavior.

Two developments marked the shift: first, Facebook introduced the Like button, making algorithmic feeds dominant. At the same time, smartphones reached mass saturation. The combination led to the explosion of social media as a vector for dopamine exploitation.

This is not just about YouTube and TikTok, however. Dopamine Capitalism also includes:

- Ultra-processed food engineered for hyper-palatability
- Gambling and investing apps with slot-machine feedback loops
- Dating platforms built on intermittent reward
- E-commerce services that deliver “doorbell dopamine”
- Fitness and productivity tools that gamify behavior

The business model is no longer attention capture. It's behavior design.

3. Attention Society (2023–present)

The arrival of Generative AI marks the next inflection point. Intelligence becomes abundant, content becomes infinite, and creation becomes frictionless.

But here is the mechanism that most analyses miss: when the cost of intelligence collapses, the constraint doesn't disappear; it migrates. It moves from *what you can produce* to *what you choose to attend to*.

The bottleneck is no longer capability, but discernment.

An Attention Society is one in which attention is simultaneously:

- The primary individual capacity
- The primary economic bottleneck
- A political and cultural fault line
- A competitive advantage at the individual level

Consider what Elon Musk's acquisition of Twitter revealed: the most strategically sophisticated actors no longer compete for market share *within* the old Attention Economy. They compete to *own the infrastructure of attention itself*. Musk didn't buy a social media company. He acquired a civilization-scale attention-routing system — and paid \$44 billion for it, even though the underlying business was impaired. That price wasn't rational on the commercial merits alone. But it was a savvy valuation of what such infrastructure is worth *when attention organizes everything*.

If the Attention Economy describes a market, and Dopamine Capitalism describes a behavioral system, the Attention Society describes a civilizational condition.

Welcome to the Attention Society

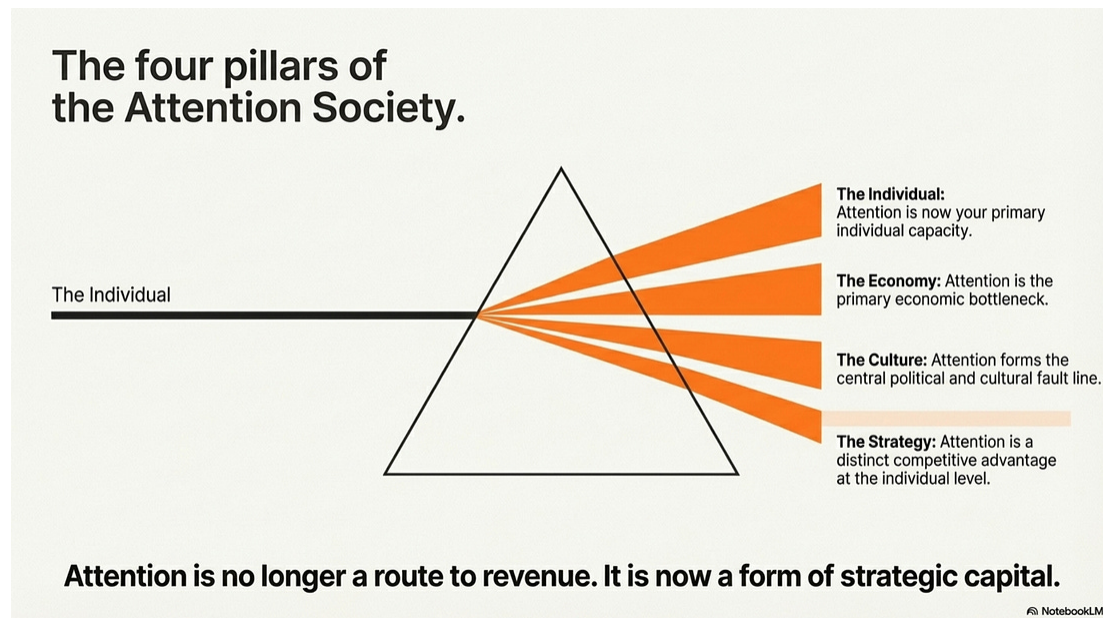
Politics also operates as an attention system. Campaigns, press cycles, and even policy announcements are increasingly designed for maximum visibility and narrative control rather than governance.

Political power now flows to those who can capture and direct attention, not just to those in office.

Virality has become a primary driver of **cultural** relevance. Audience now matters as much as substance. A mediocre product with a great platform will outperform a great one that no one sees.

In the Attention Society, distribution increasingly determines success.

Visibility has migrated upstream of status. This is the Attention Society's most disorienting inversion: **being seen now precedes being recognized as skilled — in politics, in culture, and increasingly in business.** Awards are nice. But attention is the asset that awards now follow, not precede.



Why This Matters Now

For most of the past decade, the challenge was managing distraction. That framing is now insufficient. The Attention Society doesn't merely entertain you; it now entrains you. The crucial challenge is no longer filtering noise. It's directing your attention, taste, and agency in an environment purpose-built to appropriate all three.

1. Intelligence Is Flooding the System. Attention Is the New Constraint.

AI has collapsed the cost of intelligence. You can generate ideas, analysis, and content instantly. You are no longer paid to have all the answers, but to apply discernment to the right problems and opportunities.

The ultimate advantage now comes from deciding *what* matters.

2. Attention Will Continue to be the World's Most Strategic Asset

Attention is no longer just a resource; It's a form of capital now. It compounds, can be invested or squandered, and like all capital, it flows toward those who manage it deliberately.

AI optimists argue that AGI will create an era of radical abundance. If they're right, we will have enough of everything. But some things are, by their very nature, limited. At the top of that list is Attention.

Think of attention as the cognitive equivalent of the speed of light: a hard physical constant that no amount of technological progress can expand. AI can help you allocate it more precisely, but it can't manufacture more of it. That asymmetry is permanent — and it is the foundation of every strategic advantage available in the Attention Society.

Attention is everything, and it will remain the final scarcity into the future.

3. The New Strategic Divide

You are no longer paid to have the answers.



The advantage now belongs exclusively to the person who decides what matters.

© NotebookLM

Here's the uncomfortable truth: Most people will fail this test. They will outsource their attention to feeds, their taste to algorithms, and their agency to systems designed to keep them passive and pleasantly distracted.

But a small minority recognizes what's happening. They will treat attention as capital. They will train their ability to filter, focus, and execute, and they will use AI as leverage rather than becoming subject to it.

The question is no longer whether attention matters, but whether *you* control it.

The executives who will thrive in the Attention Society **will be the ones who have developed what I call *Attention Capital***— the disciplined capacity to direct focus, exercise discernment, and act with agency in an environment engineered to strip all three away.

This week, run a single diagnostic: audit one full workday and ask not where you intended your attention to go, but where it actually landed. Most executives are genuinely surprised to discover that their most

valuable cognitive resource is being quietly allocated by other people's priorities.

The Attention Society has arrived. The critical question to ask yourself now is: *Are you prepared for it?*

Note: This is the **ninth** in a series exploring Attention's centrality in the 21st Century and the need to manage it as a strategic resource. To explore the others, go [here](#).

*Io*NTELLIGENCE by Ion Valis. I'm an **executive coach** and **personal AI strategist**. To learn more about my work, please visit [my website](#) or [connect with me on LinkedIn](#).
